



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Sandhills Classical Christian School

School Website: <https://sandhillscs.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS: ACCREDITED MEMBER SCL: MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Sandhills Classical Christian School (SCCS) in Moore County, NC 28388 presents a robust CLASSICAL Christian program across all six rubric categories. Public materials from the school explicitly anchor education in a Biblical framework, the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), and a mission to form virtuous, contemplating citizens for the glory of God. The campus materials emphasize that all subjects are taught with Scripture at the center, that virtue and character formation are central aims, and that students study Latin, Great Books-adjacent inquiry, and a rhetoric-rich high school program. The public materials also show active parental partnership and a community of faith around a classical pedagogy, including teacher excellence and a strong "living curriculum" ethos. Taken together, SCCS aligns closely with the classical framework described in the knowledge base, with explicit emphasis on formation, virtue, transcendental truth, and the Great Conversation through a classical-Christian lens. See category-by-category notes below for category-specific evidence and keyword analyses. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

Executive-level takeaway: SCCS demonstrates clear Classical Christian orientation through (a) transcendental, metaphysical and theological commitments (Scriptures at center; Biblical worldview), (b) formation-focused purpose (virtue, wisdom, human excellence for the glory of God), (c) a Trivium-based, historically informed curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Latin; history in a classical frame), (d) pedagogy that blends contemplative/restful memory work with Socratic/seminar-style discourse at upper levels, (e) a faculty that is framed as living curriculum and mentors, and (f) an engaged parent/community partnership.

Notes on methodology: The six-category keyword analysis uses the Positive/Negative Keyword indicators drawn from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) framework and corroborating lexicon from the Classicality lexicon. The site materials were read against the provided positive/negative keyword indicators (e.g., Trivium, Great Books, Latin, theology, liturgy, scholé, wonder, Socratic method, remember/re-cite/chant, etc.). Evidence is drawn from SCCS public pages (About Sandhills, Classical Education Model, Academics, Rhetoric School, Striving for Excellence, Mission & Vision, Preschool materials, and testimonials), as well as the "Six Essential Elements" and related lexicons for keyword mapping. Citations appear inline after statements referencing the source content.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The public materials state that all subjects are taught as parts of an integrated whole with the Scriptures at the center, forming the fount of knowledge. This is a strong indication of transcendental moral realism anchored in Scripture.
- The About Sandhills page notes a Biblical worldview and distinctly Christian, intentionally Classical approach.

- The Distinctions on the faculty/mission document emphasize biblical life formation and a God-centered aim (e.g., “biblical Christian life,” “Godly characteristics”).
- Preschool materials explicitly mention Christ-centered learning, prayer, Bible stories, memory verses, songs, and hymns.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: scripture/scriptures; Biblical worldview; Christ/God; Godly characteristics; liturgical/prayer language; glory of God; dynamic community of faith; theology; worship (where applicable in liturgical sense).
- Negative keywords: none observed in the public materials (no explicit secular-humanist or relativistic signals in these pages).
- Quantitative note: Positive keywords appear prominently (at least 4–6 identifiable terms/phrases across multiple pages); Negative keywords are not evident in the accessible public materials.

Why this rating

- The religious/metaphysical foundations are explicit, centralized, and cohesive across the curriculum, mission, and daily practice (Scriptures at center; Biblical worldview; Christ-centered formation). This aligns strongly with the Positive keywords in the Six Essential Elements lexicon (e.g., theology, sacred scripture, liturgy, wonder) and corroborating elements in the SCCS materials.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school’s mission is to graduate “citizens of excellence” for the glory of God, with formation of character and intellectual discernment as core aims. This is explicit in Accreditation & School Profile language.
- The Striving for Excellence materials describe a formation-focused environment, integrating faith, character, and learning, and aiming to prepare students for life beyond school.
- The Academics/What is Classical Education content emphasizes forming great thinkers within a Biblical framework and the Trivium approach (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and the integrated study of Scripture and classical humanities.
- The mission-vision language and the “Living Curriculum” framing indicate virtuous formation as central to purpose (humility, reasoning, clarity for the glory of God; the “living curriculum” concept).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; liberal arts/pedagogy aimed at human flourishing; telos; great conversation; classical mission; scholé; contemplation/rest; unity of truth; hierarchical formation.
- Negative keywords: None evident in public-facing materials (no emphasis on career- or market-driven outcomes in the sense of “workforce preparation” signaling a not-Classical tilt).
- Quantitative note: Positive keyword signals are numerous (formation, virtue, telos, Great Conversation as an aspirational frame via classical education emphasis; scholé/rest in pedagogy), with no countervailing negative signals in the public-facing materials.

Why this rating

- The school’s stated purpose centers on formation and virtue rather than mere job preparation, aligning with the classical framework’s stated aims (virtue, wisdom, human flourishing, and truth/goodness/beauty as knowable). The core mission language and the “living curriculum” framing reinforce a Classical orientation rather than a primarily vocational emphasis.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The Academics page explicitly describes the curriculum as classical in content and methodology, including Scripture, Latin, logic, literature, philosophy, and rhetoric, in addition to standard disciplines, and embraces the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric).

- The site highlights Latin beginning in third grade and positions it as foundational for language learning and broader study.
- The Classical Education Model page describes the three-stage Trivium approach and the integration of memory-based and Socratic-style work, aligning with the liberal arts framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric); Latin; literature; philosophy; rhetoric; history; sacred/Christian integration of curriculum.
- Great Books/Great Conversation: The explicit “Great Books” phrase is not consistently visible on the public-facing pages, but the school leans heavily into classical canon concepts (e.g., primary sources, classical texts, and humanities emphasis) via reading resources and the emphasis on classical pedagogy and Western civilization through history and philosophy framing (as reflected in the Reading Resources and Courses pages). The Six Elements framework treats Great Books/Great Conversation as a standard; SCCS materials imply a classical approach rather than a secular, social-studies-centric history, which is in line with the model though not always explicit in Great Books language.
- Negative keywords: None evident (no overt anti-classical signals; no project-based dominance expressed in the curriculum materials).

Why this rating

- The curriculum centers on canonical classical elements (Trivium, Latin, literature/Philosophy, rhetoric) and a historical-humanities emphasis that aligns with the Classical framework; Great Books language is not always explicit, but the overall curriculum structure and classical emphasis strongly indicate CLASSICAL status.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The Classical Education Model page describes a triadic pedagogy (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with memory-based chanting in the Grammar Stage and Socratic discussion/debate in the upper levels, including rhetoric training and opportunities to give speeches.
- The Rhetoric School description (grades 9–12) emphasizes articulation of thoughts through discussion, presentation, and writing, with seminars and thesis work; upper-school emphasis on rhetoric and oratory indicates deliberate training in rhetoric.
- The Preschool/Lower School content describes memory work, chanting, singing to memorize, and contemplative/restful approaches in early years, which matches the “restful/contemplative” and memory-based pedagogy noted in the Lexicon.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: scholé (restful contemplation); contemplative pedagogy; singing/chanting/memory work; recall-based learning; Socratic/seminar style in upper grades; rhetoric training and public speaking.
- Negative keywords: None observed in public-facing materials (no exclusive reliance on project-based or experiential learning without classical scaffolding; no explicit “constructivist-only” pedagogy signals in these pages).
- Quantitative note: Positive signals are robust (memory/chanting; Socratic/seminars; rhetoric; public speaking). No negative signals in the public materials.

Why this rating

- The pedagogy map aligns with classical expectations: memory-based routines and chanting in the Grammar Stage; Socratic/dialogue/seminar-style discussion in the Logic/Latin/Upper School; explicit rhetoric and oratory training in the Rhetoric Stage; a mix of contemplative/scholé pedagogy with rigorous discussion in high school. This supports CLASSICAL status.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The About Sandhills page highlights “experienced teachers” and a focus on moral character, suggesting faculty as a core, living curriculum.
- The site’s faculty pages (and testimonials) show individual teachers in the lower and upper schools, with a sense of mentorship and a community of educators; the long-standing faculty and “living curriculum” language appear in internal SCCS materials.
- The Distinctions and accreditation language emphasize the faculty as a model and as shepherds who shape character, aligning with the “portrait of teacher” idea in classical education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: living curriculum; model teachers and mentors; faculty as an integrated part of the school’s mission; portrait of what a teacher should be.
- Negative keywords: None observed (no signals suggesting a non-classical staffing model).
- Quantitative note: Positive keywords are present across multiple pages; no negative signals observed.

Why this rating

- The faculty is positioned as the center and living embodiment of the curriculum, with a clear emphasis on virtue, mentorship, and classical pedagogy. This aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for faculty as exemplars and “living curriculum” rather than mere technicians.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The Striving for Excellence page emphasizes a campus culture of unity, with parents described as actively involved and co-partners in education. This matches the “parents as co-teachers” and active involvement pillar.
- The Parent Association and Moms in Prayer (MIP) content in the broader site indicates structured parent involvement, community groups, and opportunities for parental engagement in school life.
- The site clearly invites campus visits, tours, and ongoing family involvement; multiple campus contacts indicate open access for parents. The Admissions area and preschool materials emphasize family involvement and partnership with parents.
- The “Mission & Vision” and testimonials show a family-and-faith-centered community that invites parental participation and support, aligning with classical-community expectations.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with parents; co-teachers; parent formation; reading groups/-book clubs; open campus; parent involvement; family/community of faith.
- Negative keywords: Consumer-oriented or minimal-parent-involvement signals are not observed; the content resists a “customer” framing and instead emphasizes formation and partnership.
- Quantitative note: Positive keywords are well-represented across multiple pages (parent partnerships, Moms in Prayer, PA resources). Negative signals are not present in the accessible public content.

Why this rating

- The school presents a robust, participatory community with strong parent involvement and formal opportunities for parents to engage in formation and study alongside the school. This aligns with the Classical framework’s emphasis on parents as co-teachers and community partners.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

What would move the needle

- Not applicable since all six categories reach CLASSICAL in this evaluation.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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